



MAPPING SYNTHESIS REPORT

**HIGHLIGHTING KEY LEGAL ADVOCACY TRENDS
AND REGIONAL LEGAL "HOTSPOTS" OF YOUTH
LED ORGANIZATIONS IN EAST AFRICA REGION.**



2026



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Executive Summary

This report presents findings from the Eastern Africa component of the Regional Mapping and Landscape Assessment of Youth-led Organizations within the Eastern and Southern Africa (ESA) region. The assessment was undertaken to map youth-led civil society organizations (CSOs), analyze emerging thematic and legal advocacy priorities, examine institutional and operational trends, and generate insight into the evolving landscape of youth-led organizing within Eastern Africa.

The review focused specifically on organizations from Tanzania, Kenya, Uganda, and Ethiopia. However, the consolidated dataset provided for analysis reflected significant disparities in regional participation and response representation. Tanzania emerged as the only country with extractable and analyzable organizational data within the reviewed dataset, while no complete extractable entries were identified for Kenya, Uganda, or Ethiopia at the time of analysis. Consequently, the findings presented within this report are primarily informed by Tanzanian organizational responses and should therefore be interpreted within the context of uneven regional data representation.

Despite these methodological limitations, the Tanzania findings provide important insight into broader youth-led organizing dynamics shaping Eastern Africa. The assessment reveals an evolving youth-led civil society ecosystem characterized by strong grassroots engagement, rights-based programming, community-centered advocacy, increasing climate justice engagement, and growing youth participation within local accountability and civic processes.

The findings demonstrate that youth-led organizations are increasingly occupying critical advocacy and community engagement spaces traditionally dominated by larger and more institutionalized civil society actors. Organizations reflected strong engagement in areas including gender justice, prevention of violence against women and girls, sexual and reproductive health and rights (SRHR), climate justice, youth civic participation, economic empowerment, and community accountability initiatives.

A significant trend emerging from the assessment is the growing adoption of integrated and intersectional advocacy approaches. Many youth-led organizations increasingly recognize the interconnected relationship between gender inequality, economic vulnerability, climate insecurity, educational exclusion, and youth marginalization. As a result, organizations are progressively adopting more holistic and community-responsive programming models aimed at addressing multiple dimensions of social inequality simultaneously.

The findings further highlight the strong grassroots orientation of many youth-led organizations. Unlike larger national organizations that often operate through highly institutionalized structures, many youth-led initiatives appear deeply embedded within local communities and maintain close engagement with affected populations. This positioning strengthens community trust, accessibility, and responsiveness while also reinforcing the role of youth-led organizations as important actors within local advocacy and social transformation processes.

At the same time, the assessment reveals persistent structural and operational barriers affecting the sustainability and long-term effectiveness of youth-led organizations across the region. Key challenges identified include financial insecurity, limited institutional development, inadequate legal advocacy capacity, fragmented regional coordination mechanisms, and limited access to formal policy and decision-making spaces. Many

organizations continue to operate within resource-constrained environments characterized by short-term project funding, reliance on volunteerism, and limited institutional support.

The assessment therefore underscores the need for increased investment in strengthening youth-led ecosystems across Eastern Africa. This includes strengthening institutional capacity, expanding access to sustainable and flexible funding mechanisms, improving regional coordination and movement-building, supporting legal advocacy and policy engagement, and creating more inclusive pathways for youth participation within governance and decision-making processes.

Overall, the report concludes that youth-led organizations across Eastern Africa continue to demonstrate significant resilience, innovation, community legitimacy, and commitment to social transformation despite operating within challenging institutional and financial environments. With targeted investment and sustained support, youth-led organizations hold substantial potential to strengthen civic participation, advance rights-based advocacy, and contribute meaningfully to inclusive and sustainable development across the region.

Background and Regional Context

Across Eastern and Southern Africa, young people continue to constitute a significant proportion of the region's population and remain central to ongoing social, political, economic, and environmental transformations. Despite their demographic significance and growing influence within civic spaces, many young people continue to face persistent structural challenges including unemployment, gender inequality, shrinking civic space, climate vulnerability, exclusion from decision-making processes, and limited access to essential services and opportunities.

In response to these realities, youth-led civil society organizations have increasingly emerged as important actors within regional advocacy, governance, and development landscapes. Unlike more traditional and highly institutionalized civil society structures, many youth-led organizations operate in close proximity to grassroots communities and are often deeply informed by lived experiences and local realities. This community-centered positioning has enabled youth-led organizations to play a growing role in advancing rights awareness, community mobilization, social accountability, gender justice, climate action, economic empowerment, and youth participation initiatives across the region.

The increasing visibility and influence of youth-led organizations reflects a broader shift within regional advocacy ecosystems, where young people are no longer viewed solely as beneficiaries of development interventions but are increasingly positioning themselves as organizers, advocates, movement builders, and contributors to policy and social transformation processes.

Within Eastern Africa specifically, youth-led advocacy has become particularly important in response to rising youth unemployment, gender-based violence, child marriage, educational exclusion, climate-related economic vulnerabilities, and continued concerns around democratic participation and youth representation within governance structures. Youth-led organizations are therefore increasingly occupying critical spaces in promoting inclusion, strengthening community resilience, and amplifying youth voices within local and national conversations around justice, equity, and accountability.

This assessment contributes to broader regional efforts aimed at understanding the operational realities, advocacy priorities, institutional capacities, and emerging trends shaping youth-led organizing within Eastern Africa.

Purpose and Objectives of the Assessment

The overall purpose of the assessment was to map and analyze youth-led organizations operating within the ESA region and generate evidence on emerging advocacy and legal engagement trends.

The specific objectives included:

- Identifying youth-led civil society organizations operating within Eastern Africa;
- Mapping organizational thematic priorities and areas of intervention;
- Assessing emerging legal and advocacy trends;
- Identifying regional legal and policy “hotspots” affecting youth constituencies;

- Understanding operational strengths and institutional gaps affecting youth-led organizing;
- Generating evidence-based recommendations to strengthen regional youth-led advocacy ecosystems.

Methodology

The assessment utilized a consolidated regional survey dataset containing submissions from youth-led organizations across the Eastern and Southern Africa (ESA) region. The analytical process focused specifically on extracting and reviewing responses linked to Tanzania, Kenya, Uganda, and Ethiopia in line with the scope of the Eastern Africa regional mapping assignment.

The methodology adopted a desk-based qualitative and thematic analysis approach aimed at identifying emerging patterns, advocacy priorities, institutional trends, and operational realities shaping youth-led organizing within the region. The assessment involved a systematic review of organizational entries within the dataset, including country-specific filtering, extraction of relevant organizational profiles, and thematic coding of responses.

Particular attention was given to understanding the nature of youth-led advocacy, legal engagement approaches, community-focused interventions, and organizational sustainability challenges reflected within the responses. The analysis further examined recurring trends related to organizational thematic focus areas, target populations, advocacy priorities, institutional capacity, partnerships and networks, operational constraints, and funding sustainability concerns.

In addition, the assessment incorporated comparative review of the available regional representation in order to identify patterns in participation, data availability, and visibility of youth-led organizations across the targeted Eastern African countries.

The methodological approach was designed to generate both quantitative mapping insights and qualitative narrative analysis capable of capturing the evolving landscape of youth-led organizing, rights-based advocacy, and community engagement within Eastern Africa.

Data Availability and Assessment Limitations

A key methodological observation emerging from the assessment relates to uneven data representation across the targeted Eastern African countries. While the assessment anticipated broader participation and representation from Tanzania, Kenya, Uganda, and Ethiopia, the survey dataset deployed and provided for analysis reflected substantially extractable responses primarily from Tanzania-based organizations.

Although references were identified regarding outreach efforts involving organizations from Kenya, these were not reflected as complete and analyzable entries within the uploaded dataset at the time of assessment. Consequently, the mapping findings and thematic analysis presented within this report are largely informed by responses from organizations operating in Tanzania.

The table below summarizes the data availability trends identified during the assessment:

Country	Data Availability Status	Observations
Tanzania	Data Extracted	Multiple analyzable organizational entries available
Kenya	Minimal Data Extracted	Limited incomplete references identified, with no fully analyzable entries available
Uganda	No Data Extracted	No complete extractable entries identified
Ethiopia	No Data Extracted	No complete extractable entries identified

This limitation has important implications for regional comparative analysis and interpretation of findings. First, it reflects common challenges associated with regional assessments, including uneven survey response rates, limited outreach penetration, varying institutional capacities among youth-led organizations, data synchronization gaps, digital accessibility barriers, and participation fatigue among grassroots actors.

Second, the absence of robust data from Kenya, Uganda, and Ethiopia constrained the ability to conduct broader comparative analysis across all targeted Eastern African countries. As a result, trends identified within the report should not be interpreted as fully representative of the wider Eastern African region.

Third, the limitation itself reflects broader structural realities affecting youth-led organizing across the region, particularly around visibility, documentation, institutional inclusion, and participation within regional knowledge-generation processes. Smaller and grassroots youth-led organizations often operate with limited administrative capacity and inconsistent documentation systems, which may affect participation in regional mapping and research initiatives.

The report therefore presents findings with methodological transparency and acknowledges that the analysis is primarily informed by Tanzanian organizational responses. Nonetheless, the findings still provide important insight into emerging trends shaping youth-led advocacy, rights-based organizing, and community-centered engagement within Eastern Africa.

Overview of Youth-Led Organizing in Tanzania

The Tanzania findings provide important insight into the evolving landscape of youth-led advocacy and civil society engagement within Eastern Africa. The assessment demonstrates that youth-led organizations in Tanzania are increasingly playing a significant role in addressing social inequalities, promoting community accountability, and advancing rights-based development approaches within their communities.

The extracted organizations reflected strong engagement in community-centered advocacy and grassroots mobilization across a range of thematic areas including gender equality, youth empowerment, climate justice, civic participation, education, and social protection. The findings suggest that youth-led organizations are increasingly positioning themselves not only as service providers, but also as important actors in shaping community dialogue, strengthening civic engagement, and promoting social transformation at local level.

A recurring trend emerging from the assessment is the strong rights-based orientation reflected across many youth-led initiatives. Organizations demonstrated growing commitment to promoting inclusion, equity, participation, and community resilience through advocacy approaches grounded in local realities and lived experiences. Many organizations appear to prioritize direct engagement with communities through awareness campaigns, peer education, community forums, grassroots organizing, and youth-centered mobilization efforts.

The findings further indicate that youth-led organizations in Tanzania are increasingly functioning as important platforms for youth agency and collective action. Through their work, these organizations are contributing to stronger community participation, increased awareness of social justice concerns, and greater youth engagement within local accountability and governance processes.

An important observation emerging from the dataset is the strong grassroots orientation of many youth-led organizations. Unlike larger and highly institutionalized national organizations, many youth-led initiatives appear deeply embedded within local communities and maintain close proximity to the populations they serve. This community-centered positioning enables organizations to respond more directly to emerging local challenges and strengthens trust, accessibility, and community ownership within their interventions.

At the same time, the findings suggest that this grassroots orientation also presents certain institutional limitations. While close community engagement strengthens legitimacy and responsiveness, many organizations continue to experience challenges related to institutional visibility, long-term sustainability, technical capacity, and access to funding opportunities. Smaller grassroots organizations often operate with limited operational infrastructure despite demonstrating strong community impact and local relevance.

Overall, the assessment highlights the growing importance of youth-led organizations within Tanzania's civic and development landscape. The findings demonstrate that youth-led organizing continues to evolve beyond traditional youth engagement models toward more community-driven, rights-based, and socially responsive approaches capable of addressing complex social, economic, and governance challenges affecting young people and marginalized populations across the country.

Thematic Analysis of Advocacy Priorities

The assessment findings reveal that youth-led organizations across Eastern Africa are increasingly engaging in advocacy and programming that responds directly to the social, economic, and governance challenges affecting young people and marginalized communities. Although the organizations represented within the dataset operate across diverse thematic areas, several recurring advocacy priorities emerged consistently throughout the analysis.

The findings demonstrate that youth-led organizations are not only responding to immediate community needs, but are also increasingly positioning themselves as important actors in advancing rights-based advocacy, social accountability, community resilience, and inclusive development. The thematic priorities identified throughout the assessment reflect both the lived realities of communities and the evolving role of youth-led organizations within broader civic and development ecosystems.

6.1 Gender Equality and Prevention of Gender-Based Violence

Gender equality and the prevention of gender-based violence emerged as one of the most prominent thematic priorities across the Tanzania responses. The findings indicate that many youth-led organizations are actively engaged in advocacy and community interventions aimed at addressing violence against women and girls, harmful social norms, child marriage, educational exclusion, and barriers affecting adolescent girls and young women.

Organizations demonstrated strong commitment to promoting gender justice through community sensitization, awareness campaigns, peer engagement, youth forums, and educational initiatives focused on strengthening protection and empowerment for girls and young women. Many organizations also integrated menstrual health awareness and support for adolescent girls within broader gender equality programming.

The prominence of gender-based violence prevention within the findings reflects the continuing urgency of gender inequality issues affecting communities across Eastern Africa. The assessment further suggests that youth-led organizations increasingly recognize the relationship between gender justice, economic vulnerability, educational access, and civic participation.

Rather than relying heavily on litigation-oriented approaches, most organizations appear to prioritize prevention-focused and community-centered advocacy strategies aimed at shifting harmful attitudes, increasing awareness, and strengthening local accountability. This reflects the reality that many youth-led organizations operate within contexts where formal protection systems remain under-resourced or inaccessible to affected populations.

Importantly, the findings indicate that youth-led organizations frequently operate at the intersection of advocacy and direct community support, often filling critical gaps where institutional responses remain limited.

6.2 Sexual and Reproductive Health and Rights (SRHR)

Sexual and reproductive health and rights emerged as another highly visible and recurring thematic area within the assessment. Youth-led organizations demonstrated growing engagement in SRHR awareness, menstrual health and hygiene advocacy, youth health education, prevention of teenage pregnancy, and broader conversations around bodily autonomy and reproductive rights.

The findings reflect broader regional realities where many adolescents and young people continue to face barriers in accessing accurate information, youth-friendly health services, and safe spaces for engagement on sexual and reproductive health issues. In response, youth-led organizations are increasingly positioning themselves as important platforms for awareness creation, peer education, and community dialogue around SRHR-related concerns.

The assessment further indicates that SRHR advocacy is often closely linked to broader gender justice and protection efforts. Many organizations appear to understand the relationship between reproductive health, educational retention for girls, prevention of child marriage, reduction of exploitation, and broader efforts aimed at addressing stigma and discrimination affecting young people.

Youth-led organizations therefore continue to occupy important spaces within communities where public systems and institutional support mechanisms remain insufficient, particularly in relation to youth-centered engagement and community-level awareness creation.

6.3 Climate Justice and Environmental Advocacy

An important emerging trend identified throughout the assessment is the increasing integration of climate justice and environmental advocacy within youth-led programming and organizing. The findings demonstrate that youth-led organizations are increasingly engaging in environmental conservation initiatives, climate awareness campaigns, community resilience efforts, sustainable livelihood interventions, and green entrepreneurship activities.

This growing engagement reflects increasing recognition among youth-led organizations that climate vulnerability extends beyond environmental concerns and is deeply connected to broader social and economic inequalities affecting communities across the region.

The findings suggest that organizations increasingly understand the relationship between climate change and issues such as economic insecurity, rural poverty, food insecurity, gender inequality, and youth unemployment. As a result, climate justice advocacy is no longer being approached solely as an environmental issue, but rather as part of broader conversations around resilience, livelihoods, equity, and social protection.

This evolving understanding represents an important shift within youth-led advocacy landscapes. Organizations are increasingly adopting more integrated and intersectional approaches that connect climate action with community development, economic empowerment, and rights-based advocacy efforts.

The findings therefore highlight the growing role of youth-led organizations in advancing localized and community-driven climate responses capable of addressing both environmental and socio-economic vulnerabilities

6.4 Youth Civic Participation and Governance

The assessment findings also reveal strong interest among youth-led organizations in promoting youth inclusion within governance and decision-making processes. Several organizations demonstrated active engagement in leadership development, civic education, accountability initiatives, youth participation forums, and community organizing efforts aimed at strengthening democratic participation and civic engagement among young people.

This growing focus on governance and participation reflects broader frustrations among young people regarding exclusion from public decision-making spaces and limited representation within governance systems. Youth-led organizations increasingly function as important platforms through which young people organize collectively, articulate community concerns, and participate in local accountability processes.

The findings further suggest that many organizations are working to strengthen awareness around rights, citizenship, participation, and leadership among young people at community level. Through these efforts, youth-led organizations contribute to strengthening civic agency and promoting more inclusive participation within local governance processes.

However, the assessment also indicates that many organizations continue to face barriers in accessing formal policy engagement opportunities and institutional governance spaces. As a

result, most advocacy efforts remain concentrated at community level rather than being fully integrated within national policy and decision-making frameworks.

This highlights the need for stronger pathways that support meaningful youth participation within governance systems and formal policy processes across the region.

6.5 Economic Empowerment and Livelihoods

Economic empowerment and livelihood strengthening emerged as another important thematic priority within the assessment. Youth-led organizations demonstrated growing engagement in entrepreneurship promotion, skills development, financial literacy, income-generation initiatives, and livelihood support interventions aimed at improving economic opportunities for young people and vulnerable communities.

The findings reflect broader regional realities where youth unemployment, economic insecurity, and limited livelihood opportunities continue to affect large segments of the population across Eastern Africa.

Importantly, the assessment indicates that many youth-led organizations increasingly understand economic empowerment not only as an income-generation issue, but also as a broader protection and resilience concern. Organizations frequently linked economic vulnerability to issues such as exploitation, early marriage, transactional relationships, educational exclusion, and social marginalization.

As a result, economic empowerment interventions are increasingly integrated within broader advocacy efforts focused on gender equality, youth protection, community resilience, and social justice.

The findings therefore demonstrate that youth-led organizations are adopting more holistic approaches that recognize the interconnected relationship between economic security, dignity, rights protection, and long-term community wellbeing.

Emerging Regional Legal Advocacy Trends

The assessment identified several emerging legal and advocacy trends shaping youth-led organizing across Eastern Africa. The findings demonstrate that youth-led organizations are increasingly positioning themselves as important actors in advancing rights awareness, community mobilization, and social accountability within their respective communities. Although the organizational approaches and thematic priorities vary, a common pattern emerging from the assessment is the growing emphasis on community-centered and rights-based advocacy models.

7.1 Community-Centered Rights Advocacy

The findings indicate that most youth-led organizations prioritize advocacy approaches that are deeply rooted within community engagement and grassroots mobilization processes. Rather than relying primarily on formal legal mechanisms or institutional advocacy channels, many organizations focus on increasing public awareness, strengthening prevention efforts, promoting peer engagement, and facilitating community sensitization around critical social justice and human rights issues.

This approach reflects the reality that many youth-led organizations operate in close proximity to grassroots communities where awareness gaps, harmful social norms, stigma, and unequal power dynamics continue to contribute to rights violations and social exclusion. As a result, organizations often position community engagement and public education as critical entry points for advancing social change and strengthening community accountability.

The assessment further suggests that youth-led organizations are increasingly utilizing participatory and youth-centered advocacy methods that prioritize dialogue, local engagement, peer mobilization, and community ownership. These approaches appear particularly common in areas related to gender-based violence prevention, sexual and reproductive health and rights, climate justice, youth participation, and community resilience.

Importantly, the emphasis on community-centered advocacy demonstrates the important role youth-led organizations play in bridging the gap between policy discussions and lived community realities. Their grassroots presence allows them to engage directly with affected populations, strengthen local awareness, and promote rights-based conversations within spaces that are often underserved by formal institutional systems.

The findings therefore highlight the growing importance of community-centered advocacy models in strengthening inclusive participation, promoting rights awareness, and advancing locally driven social transformation across Eastern Africa.

7.2 Limited Strategic Litigation Capacity

While the assessment findings demonstrate that many youth-led organizations maintain strong rights-based orientations and actively engage in community advocacy and social justice initiatives, there was limited evidence of sustained engagement in strategic litigation, formal legal representation, court-based advocacy, or structured policy litigation processes.

The findings suggest that most organizations primarily utilize community-centered advocacy approaches focused on awareness creation, grassroots mobilization, public sensitization, and rights education rather than formal legal intervention mechanisms. Although these approaches play an important role in strengthening community awareness and promoting social accountability, limited engagement in formal legal processes may reduce the ability of youth-led organizations to influence legal reform, challenge systemic injustices, and strengthen institutional accountability through judicial mechanisms.

Several factors appear to contribute to this limited strategic litigation capacity. The assessment indicates that many youth-led organizations continue to operate within constrained institutional and financial environments characterized by limited technical legal expertise, inadequate access to legal support systems, and broader institutional development challenges. In addition, restrictive civic environments and limited access to formal governance and legal spaces may further constrain the ability of youth-led organizations to engage effectively within judicial and policy processes.

The findings therefore highlight an important opportunity for targeted investment in legal empowerment, technical advocacy strengthening, and institutional capacity development for youth-led organizations across the region. Strengthening legal literacy, policy engagement skills, accountability advocacy, and strategic litigation capacity could significantly enhance

the ability of youth-led organizations to move beyond community sensitization toward more structured engagement with legal and governance systems.

Such investments would not only strengthen the advocacy influence of youth-led organizations but would also contribute to more inclusive, rights-based, and accountable governance processes within Eastern Africa.

7.3 Intersectional Advocacy Models

An important and emerging trend identified throughout the assessment is the increasing adoption of intersectional advocacy approaches among youth-led organizations operating within Eastern Africa. The findings suggest that youth-led organizations are increasingly moving beyond single-issue programming models and adopting more integrated advocacy frameworks that recognize the interconnected and multidimensional nature of the challenges affecting young people and marginalized communities.

Rather than addressing social issues in isolation, many organizations demonstrated growing awareness of the ways in which structural inequalities overlap and reinforce one another. As a result, advocacy and programming efforts increasingly reflect linkages between:

- Gender justice and economic vulnerability;
- Climate change and community resilience;
- Youth unemployment and social exclusion;
- Mental health and social protection;
- Civic participation and governance accountability;
- Livelihood insecurity and rights violations.

The findings reveal that youth-led organizations are increasingly integrating issues such as gender equality, climate justice, economic empowerment, mental health, youth participation, and community resilience within broader advocacy and development interventions. This reflects a growing recognition that the realities affecting young people are complex, interconnected, and shaped by multiple layers of social, economic, environmental, and political inequality.

For example, organizations working on gender-based violence were also addressing economic empowerment and educational retention for girls, recognizing the relationship between financial dependency, harmful social norms, and vulnerability to exploitation. Similarly, organizations engaged in climate advocacy increasingly linked environmental sustainability with food security, youth livelihoods, migration pressures, and gender inequality.

The assessment further suggests that this shift toward intersectional advocacy is being driven by the lived realities of communities themselves. Youth-led organizations operating at grassroots level are often directly exposed to the overlapping vulnerabilities affecting young people and therefore increasingly adopt holistic approaches capable of responding to multiple community needs simultaneously.

This evolving advocacy model represents a significant shift away from traditional siloed programming approaches that have historically separated issues such as governance,

climate action, economic development, gender equality, and social protection into isolated intervention areas.

Instead, youth-led organizations are increasingly embracing integrated and community-centered approaches that recognize that sustainable social transformation requires addressing the root causes and structural drivers of inequality in a more coordinated and inclusive manner.

The growing adoption of intersectional advocacy frameworks also presents important opportunities for strengthening multi-sectoral collaboration, integrated programming, and cross-movement solidarity within the region. By connecting diverse but interrelated issues, youth-led organizations are increasingly positioning themselves to build broader community alliances, strengthen collective advocacy, and promote more inclusive and sustainable development approaches across Eastern Africa.

Importantly, the findings suggest that intersectional advocacy approaches not only strengthen the relevance and responsiveness of youth-led interventions, but also contribute to more transformative models of social change grounded in lived experiences, community realities, and rights-based development principles.

Regional Legal and Advocacy Hotspots

The assessment identified several recurring legal and advocacy priorities emerging from the Tanzania dataset, reflecting broader socio-economic, governance, and human rights challenges affecting young people and marginalized communities across Eastern Africa. The findings demonstrate that youth-led organizations are increasingly engaging in rights-based advocacy and community mobilization around issues that directly affect social protection, inclusion, equality, and access to justice.

The identified legal and advocacy hotspots largely center around gender justice, youth participation, climate resilience, economic vulnerability, and community accountability. These thematic areas not only reflect immediate community-level concerns but also highlight the growing role of youth-led organizations in shaping conversations around structural inequality, rights protection, and inclusive governance within the region.

Importantly, the findings suggest that youth-led advocacy efforts remain strongly community-centered, with organizations prioritizing grassroots mobilization, awareness creation, prevention initiatives, and community empowerment approaches as key strategies for addressing systemic challenges.

The table below summarizes the major legal and advocacy hotspots identified during the assessment and the corresponding trends observed across the analyzed responses.

Regional Legal and Advocacy Hotspot	Key Trends and Advocacy Priorities Observed
Gender-Based Violence (GBV)	Strong focus on prevention campaigns, survivor support mechanisms, community sensitization, and awareness creation

	around violence against women and girls. Organizations demonstrated growing engagement in addressing harmful social norms, promoting gender equality, and strengthening community-level protection responses.
Child Marriage	Significant advocacy efforts centered on prevention of child marriage through community mobilization, girls' education advocacy, parental engagement, and awareness campaigns addressing harmful cultural and social practices affecting adolescent girls.
Sexual and Reproductive Health and Rights (SRHR)	Increased youth-centered advocacy around reproductive health awareness, menstrual health and hygiene, bodily autonomy, youth-friendly information dissemination, and rights education aimed at reducing stigma and improving access to SRHR-related information and services.
Climate Justice and Environmental Advocacy	Emerging youth-led climate activism focusing on environmental sustainability, community resilience, climate adaptation, and the intersection between climate vulnerability, economic insecurity, and social inequality. Organizations increasingly linked climate action with gender justice and sustainable livelihoods.
Youth Inclusion in Governance and Civic Participation	Growing advocacy around youth participation in decision-making processes, civic engagement, accountability initiatives, leadership development, and inclusion of youth voices within governance and policy spaces.
Economic Vulnerability and Livelihoods	Increased focus on entrepreneurship, livelihood strengthening, skills development, and economic empowerment interventions aimed at addressing youth unemployment, economic exclusion, and community resilience challenges.

The findings further demonstrate that many of these advocacy hotspots are deeply interconnected. For example, organizations increasingly recognize the relationship between economic vulnerability and gender-based violence, or between climate insecurity and youth unemployment. This reflects a growing shift among youth-led organizations toward more intersectional and integrated advocacy approaches that address the structural drivers of inequality rather than isolated symptoms alone.

An important trend emerging from the assessment is the increasing adoption of prevention-oriented and rights-based advocacy models. Most organizations appear to prioritize community awareness, grassroots mobilization, peer engagement, and social accountability mechanisms rather than formal litigation-based approaches. This may reflect both the community-centered nature of youth-led organizing and the institutional barriers many organizations face in accessing formal legal and policy engagement spaces.

The prominence of these thematic hotspots also highlights broader governance and development challenges affecting young people across Eastern Africa, including limited access to opportunities, unequal participation in decision-making processes, persistent gender inequalities, and growing socio-economic vulnerabilities.

Although these hotspots emerged most prominently within the Tanzania dataset, the assessment suggests that similar advocacy concerns are likely prevalent across wider

Eastern African contexts given the shared socio-economic, governance, and demographic realities affecting countries within the region. However, limited data availability from Kenya, Uganda, and Ethiopia constrained the ability to conduct broader comparative analysis across all target countries.

The findings therefore underscore the importance of strengthening youth-led advocacy ecosystems capable of responding to interconnected regional challenges through coordinated, rights-based, and community-driven approaches.

Institutional and Operational Challenges Affecting Youth-Led Organizations

The assessment findings reveal that while youth-led organizations across Eastern Africa continue to demonstrate strong commitment to community transformation, their effectiveness and long-term sustainability remain constrained by persistent institutional and structural barriers. These challenges continue to affect the ability of youth-led organizations to scale interventions, sustain advocacy efforts, strengthen institutional systems, and meaningfully influence governance and policy processes.

9.1 Funding Insecurity

Limited access to sustainable and flexible financing emerged as one of the most significant challenges affecting youth-led organizations. The findings indicate that many organizations continue to operate within highly fragile financial environments characterized by short-term and project-based funding cycles, dependence on volunteerism, and informal resource mobilization approaches.

- Most youth-led organizations appear to rely heavily on:
- Short-term donor grants tied to specific activities;
- Volunteer-driven implementation structures;
- Limited community-based fundraising initiatives;
- Small-scale project financing with minimal institutional support.

As a result, many organizations experience difficulties in maintaining operational continuity, retaining skilled personnel, investing in institutional development, and implementing long-term strategic programming.

The assessment further suggests that funding models available to youth-led organizations often prioritize short-term outputs over long-term organizational strengthening. This limits opportunities for organizations to build sustainable governance systems, invest in staff development, strengthen accountability mechanisms, and expand their advocacy influence.

Consequently, many youth-led organizations remain trapped within cycles of operational uncertainty that affect both program quality and institutional resilience.

9.2 Limited Institutional Development

The findings also reveal significant institutional development gaps affecting many youth-led organizations. While organizations demonstrate strong grassroots legitimacy, innovation, and commitment to community engagement, several continue to operate with limited organizational infrastructure and institutional systems.

Key institutional gaps identified include:

- Weak governance and accountability structures;
- Limited monitoring, evaluation, and learning systems;
- Inadequate documentation and knowledge management processes;
- Limited strategic planning and organizational development capacity.

These institutional limitations reduce organizational competitiveness for funding opportunities, partnerships, and participation in larger regional initiatives.

In several cases, organizations appear to operate with high levels of programmatic passion and community engagement but limited technical and administrative capacity necessary for long-term institutional sustainability.

The findings therefore highlight the need for investments that move beyond activity-based support toward strengthening institutional resilience, organizational governance, leadership development, and internal systems strengthening.

9.3 Limited Access to Policy Spaces

Although youth-led organizations are actively engaging communities and driving grassroots advocacy efforts, the assessment indicates that many continue to face significant barriers in accessing formal policy and governance spaces.

Organizations reported or reflected limited access to:

- National policy dialogue platforms;
- Government consultation and decision-making processes;
- Regional advocacy and coordination forums;
- Formal legal and institutional engagement mechanisms.

As a result, youth-led voices often remain underrepresented within broader governance and policy ecosystems despite their proximity to community realities and lived experiences.

The findings further suggest that youth-led organizations frequently operate at the margins of formal decision-making structures, where participation may be symbolic, inconsistent, or insufficiently institutionalized.

This exclusion limits opportunities for youth-led organizations to meaningfully influence policy reforms, resource allocation processes, and legal accountability mechanisms affecting young people across the region.

Strengthening youth participation within governance systems therefore remains critical to advancing inclusive policy engagement, democratic accountability, and rights-based development across Eastern Africa.

Opportunities for Strengthening Youth-Led Organizing

Despite the structural and operational challenges identified throughout the assessment, the findings also reveal significant opportunities for strengthening youth-led organizing and expanding the influence of youth-led organizations across Eastern Africa. The growing visibility, innovation, and grassroots legitimacy demonstrated by youth-led organizations present an important foundation for building more inclusive, responsive, and community-driven advocacy ecosystems within the region.

The assessment indicates that youth-led organizations are increasingly occupying critical spaces within social justice, civic engagement, gender equality, climate action, and community accountability movements. Their proximity to lived community realities, coupled

with their adaptability and grassroots engagement approaches, positions them as important actors in shaping transformative development and advocacy processes across Eastern Africa.

Importantly, the findings suggest that with targeted institutional investment, strengthened regional collaboration, and increased access to sustainable resources, youth-led organizations hold substantial potential to expand both their advocacy influence and long-term organizational sustainability.

10.1 Expanding Youth Leadership Ecosystems

The assessment findings demonstrate that the growing emergence and visibility of youth-led organizations across Eastern Africa presents a critical opportunity to strengthen youth leadership ecosystems, deepen regional solidarity, and advance more coordinated advocacy movements within the region. As young people continue to organize around shared social, economic, environmental, and governance challenges, youth-led organizations are increasingly becoming important platforms for collective action, civic participation, and community mobilization.

The findings reveal that many youth-led organizations are addressing interconnected issues including gender inequality, youth unemployment, climate vulnerability, civic exclusion, and barriers to justice. However, despite these shared priorities, many organizations continue to operate within fragmented and resource-constrained environments with limited opportunities for sustained collaboration, cross-border engagement, and regional coordination.

This fragmentation often limits the visibility, influence, and collective bargaining power of youth-led organizations, particularly within broader regional policy and governance spaces. At the same time, the assessment suggests that there is growing momentum and willingness among youth-led actors to build stronger alliances, expand regional engagement, and strengthen collective advocacy efforts.

The increasing presence of youth-led organizations across the region therefore presents an important opportunity to strengthen regional youth ecosystems through enhanced networking, movement-building, and cross-country solidarity initiatives. Strengthened regional collaboration could create important platforms for shared learning, mentorship, peer exchange, and coordinated advocacy around emerging regional challenges affecting young people.

The findings further indicate that stronger regional solidarity mechanisms could support:

- More coordinated advocacy campaigns and collective action initiatives;
- Increased visibility and representation of youth-led voices within regional policy spaces;
- Cross-country learning and knowledge exchange on effective advocacy approaches;
- Resource-sharing and institutional strengthening among youth-led organizations;
- Collective responses to emerging human rights, governance, and social justice concerns affecting young people across the region.

Importantly, strengthening youth leadership ecosystems is not only about improving organizational coordination, but also about strengthening youth agency, amplifying grassroots voices, and creating more inclusive regional advocacy structures capable of influencing long-term social and policy transformation.

The assessment therefore highlights the need for increased investment in regional movement-building and youth-led coordination platforms that can strengthen collective influence, promote solidarity, and support the long-term sustainability of youth-led organizing across Eastern Africa.

10.2 Strengthening Legal Advocacy Capacity

The assessment reveals important opportunities to strengthen legal advocacy and rights-based engagement among youth-led organizations.

While many organizations demonstrate strong commitment to community advocacy and rights awareness, there remains considerable potential to strengthen technical legal advocacy capacity, particularly in areas related to:

- Legal literacy and civic education;
- Human rights awareness;
- Strategic litigation and legal accountability mechanisms;
- Policy analysis and engagement;
- Evidence-based advocacy and social accountability.

The findings suggest that many youth-led organizations are already actively addressing rights-related issues at community level, particularly around gender-based violence, child marriage, SRHR, youth participation, and social justice concerns. However, their advocacy efforts remain largely community-centered and awareness-oriented, with limited engagement in formal legal and policy processes.

Targeted investments in legal empowerment and advocacy strengthening could therefore significantly enhance the ability of youth-led organizations to influence policy reforms, engage accountability systems, and participate more effectively within governance and legal frameworks.

Strengthening legal advocacy capacity also presents opportunities to bridge the gap between grassroots realities and formal institutional processes, ensuring that youth-led perspectives and lived experiences are better represented within national and regional policy spaces.

10.3 Flexible and Accessible Funding Models

The assessment findings strongly underscore the urgent need for more flexible, accessible, and youth-responsive funding mechanisms to support the sustainability and long-term growth of youth-led organizations across Eastern Africa. While youth-led organizations continue to play an increasingly important role in advancing community advocacy, social justice, civic participation, and grassroots mobilization, many continue to operate within highly fragile financial environments that undermine institutional stability and long-term impact.

The findings reveal that existing funding structures often remain inaccessible to smaller and grassroots youth-led organizations due to complex compliance requirements, rigid donor frameworks, limited institutional support financing, and short-term project-based funding cycles. As a result, many youth-led organizations continue to rely heavily on volunteer-driven structures, fragmented project financing, and informal resource mobilization approaches to sustain their operations and programming.

This financial insecurity significantly affects the ability of organizations to invest in long-term institutional development, retain skilled personnel, strengthen governance systems, and

sustain advocacy initiatives beyond short funding periods. In many cases, organizations are compelled to prioritize short-term project delivery over strategic organizational growth and long-term movement-building efforts.

The assessment further suggests that current funding models often prioritize programmatic outputs while overlooking the institutional realities and operational needs of youth-led organizations. Limited investment in core organizational systems, leadership development, staff wellbeing, governance strengthening, and operational infrastructure continues to constrain the sustainability and effectiveness of youth-led organizing within the region.

At the same time, the findings highlight important opportunities for development partners, regional institutions, philanthropic actors, and funding mechanisms to adopt more inclusive and youth-centered financing approaches capable of strengthening long-term organizational resilience and advocacy influence.

Key opportunities identified include:

- Expanding flexible grant-making models responsive to grassroots realities;
- Increasing access to core institutional and operational support funding;
- Promoting long-term partnership frameworks rather than short-term transactional funding relationships;
- Simplifying application, compliance, and reporting processes for youth-led organizations;
- Integrating institutional capacity strengthening alongside programmatic financing

Such approaches would enable youth-led organizations to transition from survival-oriented implementation models toward stronger institutional sustainability, strategic growth, and long-term advocacy engagement.

Importantly, the assessment emphasizes that investing in youth-led organizations should not be understood solely as support for isolated projects or activities. Rather, such investment represents a strategic contribution toward strengthening civic leadership, democratic participation, grassroots accountability, and community resilience across Eastern Africa.

Strengthening youth-centered funding ecosystems therefore remains essential to ensuring that youth-led organizations are not only able to sustain their operations, but are also empowered to influence policy processes, strengthen community agency, and contribute meaningfully to long-term social transformation within the region.

10.4 Climate Justice Integration

The assessment also reveals growing opportunities for integrating climate justice within broader youth-led advocacy and development programming.

Youth-led organizations increasingly demonstrate awareness of the interconnected relationship between:

- Climate vulnerability;
- Gender inequality;
- Economic insecurity;
- Food systems;
- Community resilience;
- Youth livelihoods.

This emerging intersectional understanding creates important opportunities for multi-sectoral and integrated programming approaches that position climate justice not only as an environmental issue, but also as a governance, economic, and social justice concern.

The findings suggest that youth-led organizations are particularly well-positioned to advance localized climate responses through:

- Community adaptation initiatives;
- Environmental awareness campaigns;
- Green entrepreneurship models;
- Climate resilience programming;
- Youth-centered environmental advocacy.

Strengthening climate justice integration within youth-led ecosystems could therefore contribute to more inclusive and community-responsive approaches to sustainable development across Eastern Africa.

Furthermore, youth-led organizations possess unique potential to mobilize younger populations around climate action while simultaneously linking environmental advocacy with broader conversations around equity, justice, livelihoods, and human rights.

Ultimately, the growing integration of climate justice within youth-led organizing reflects an important shift toward more holistic and transformative advocacy models capable of responding to the complex and interconnected challenges affecting communities across the region.

Strategic Recommendations

The assessment findings demonstrate both the growing potential and the persistent structural vulnerabilities affecting youth-led organizations across Eastern Africa. While youth-led organizations continue to play an increasingly important role in advancing social justice, civic engagement, gender equality, climate action, and community accountability, the findings also highlight the need for more intentional and sustained investment in strengthening youth-led ecosystems within the region.

The following recommendations are proposed to strengthen the sustainability, visibility, institutional resilience, and advocacy influence of youth-led organizations across Eastern Africa.

11.1 Strengthen Regional Coordination, Networking, and Movement-Building

The findings reveal a strong need to strengthen regional coordination and collaboration among youth-led organizations operating across Eastern Africa. Although many organizations are addressing interconnected social, economic, governance, and environmental challenges, youth-led organizing within the region remains highly fragmented, with limited opportunities for sustained cross-border engagement and collective advocacy.

There is therefore a need to invest in stronger regional networking and solidarity mechanisms capable of:

- Facilitating cross-country collaboration and peer learning;
- Strengthening collective advocacy platforms and youth-led coalitions;
- Supporting regional movement-building initiatives;
- Enhancing knowledge exchange and mentorship opportunities;

- Amplifying youth-led voices within regional governance and policy spaces.

Strengthened regional ecosystems would enable youth-led organizations to collectively address shared regional concerns including gender inequality, youth unemployment, shrinking civic space, climate vulnerability, and barriers to democratic participation.

Regional coordination platforms could also contribute to stronger collective bargaining power, increased visibility, and more coordinated responses to emerging human rights and governance challenges affecting young people across the region.

11.2 Increase Investments in Institutional Strengthening and Organizational Development

The assessment highlights the urgent need for increased investment in the institutional development and long-term sustainability of youth-led organizations.

While many organizations demonstrate strong grassroots legitimacy, innovation, and commitment to community transformation, several continue to operate with limited governance systems, weak operational infrastructure, and inadequate organizational development support.

Development partners, regional institutions, and philanthropic actors should therefore prioritize investments aimed at strengthening:

- Governance and accountability systems;
- Strategic planning and organizational development;
- Monitoring, evaluation, accountability, and learning frameworks;
- Documentation and knowledge management systems;
- Leadership development and succession planning;
- Financial management and operational systems.

Institutional strengthening support should move beyond short-term project implementation and focus on building resilient organizations capable of sustaining long-term advocacy, community engagement, and movement-building efforts.

Importantly, strengthening institutional systems within youth-led organizations is essential not only for improving operational effectiveness, but also for enhancing organizational credibility, sustainability, and ability to access larger funding and partnership opportunities.

11.3 Expand Legal Advocacy and Policy Engagement Capacity

The findings demonstrate significant opportunities to strengthen legal advocacy, policy engagement, and rights-based programming among youth-led organizations.

Although many organizations are actively addressing rights-related issues at community level, most advocacy efforts remain heavily centered on awareness creation, sensitization, and grassroots mobilization, with limited participation in formal legal and policy processes.

There is therefore a need for targeted investments aimed at strengthening:

- Legal literacy and civic education;
- Human rights awareness and accountability advocacy;
- Policy analysis and legislative engagement;

- Strategic litigation and legal empowerment approaches;
- Evidence-based advocacy and research capacity;
- Youth participation in governance and accountability processes.

Strengthening legal advocacy capacity would enable youth-led organizations to engage more effectively with policy actors, accountability systems, and governance institutions at local, national, and regional levels.

Increased investment in legal empowerment would also strengthen the ability of youth-led organizations to bridge the gap between grassroots realities and formal policy processes, ensuring that youth voices and lived experiences are meaningfully reflected within governance and legal frameworks.

11.4 Improve Access to Sustainable and Flexible Funding Mechanisms

The assessment strongly emphasizes the need for more flexible, accessible, and youth-responsive funding approaches capable of supporting the long-term sustainability of youth-led organizations.

Current funding models often remain inaccessible to smaller grassroots organizations due to complex compliance requirements, rigid donor conditions, short-term project cycles, and limited institutional support funding.

Development partners and funding institutions should therefore adopt more inclusive financing approaches that:

- Expand access to flexible and simplified grant-making mechanisms;
- Increase availability of core operational and institutional support funding;
- Promote long-term partnership models rather than short-term transactional funding relationships;
- Simplify reporting and compliance processes for grassroots organizations;
- Integrate institutional strengthening alongside programmatic financing.

More flexible funding ecosystems would allow youth-led organizations to move beyond survival-oriented programming and invest in sustainable institutional growth, leadership development, staff wellbeing, strategic advocacy, and long-term community impact.

Importantly, supporting youth-led organizations should be recognized as a strategic investment in democratic participation, civic leadership, community resilience, and inclusive development across Eastern Africa.

11.5 Strengthen Regional Data Collection, Research, and Knowledge Management Systems

The assessment findings highlight important gaps in regional data availability and documentation relating to youth-led organizing within Eastern Africa. Limited participation from several target countries constrained the ability to conduct broader comparative regional analysis and reflects wider challenges associated with documentation, visibility, and knowledge management within youth-led ecosystems.

There is therefore a need to strengthen:

- Regional mapping and documentation systems;

- Data collection methodologies and outreach strategies;
- Youth-led research and evidence-generation initiatives;
- Knowledge management and organizational documentation practices;
- Regional learning and information-sharing platforms.

Improved data systems would support stronger evidence-based advocacy, increase visibility of youth-led organizations, and strengthen understanding of emerging regional trends affecting young people and grassroots movements.

Strengthening research and documentation systems would also contribute to more inclusive regional assessments and ensure that youth-led organizations are better represented within policy discussions, funding priorities, and development planning processes.

11.6 Support Intersectional and Integrated Programming Approaches

The findings reveal increasing recognition among youth-led organizations that social inequalities affecting young people are deeply interconnected. Organizations are increasingly linking climate justice, gender equality, economic empowerment, SRHR, governance, and community resilience within their advocacy and programming approaches.

Development actors and regional institutions should therefore support more intersectional and integrated programming models capable of responding to the complex realities affecting young people across the region.

Particular attention should be given to strengthening programming that connects:

- Climate justice and economic resilience;
- Gender equality and governance participation;
- Youth livelihoods and social protection;
- SRHR and educational inclusion;
- Community resilience and sustainable development.

Integrated programming approaches would strengthen the ability of youth-led organizations to address root causes of vulnerability while promoting more holistic and community-centered development responses.

Such approaches are particularly important within contexts where young people experience overlapping forms of exclusion, inequality, and socio-economic vulnerability.

11.7 Strengthen Youth Participation in Policy and Governance Processes

The assessment findings indicate that despite growing youth-led activism and grassroots engagement, many young people and youth-led organizations continue to face barriers in accessing formal policy and governance spaces.

There is therefore a need for governments, regional institutions, civil society actors, and development partners to create stronger and more institutionalized pathways for youth participation within decision-making processes.

Efforts should focus on:

- Increasing youth representation within policy dialogue and consultation mechanisms;
- Strengthening youth participation in governance and accountability structures;

- Supporting youth-led participation within regional advocacy forums;
- Creating more inclusive civic engagement spaces for young people;
- Strengthening partnerships between youth-led organizations and public institutions.

Meaningful youth participation should move beyond symbolic engagement toward genuine inclusion within policy formulation, implementation, monitoring, and accountability processes.

Strengthening youth participation in governance systems is critical to advancing democratic accountability, responsive leadership, and inclusive development across Eastern Africa.

Ultimately, ensuring that youth-led organizations are recognized not merely as beneficiaries but as equal stakeholders within governance and development ecosystems remains essential to strengthening long-term social transformation within the region.

Conclusion

Youth-led organizations continue to play an increasingly important role in shaping advocacy, social justice, and community transformation across Eastern Africa. Although the available dataset reflected limited representation from Kenya, Uganda, and Ethiopia, the findings from Tanzania provide important insight into the evolving landscape of youth-led organizing within the region.

The assessment demonstrates that youth-led organizations are increasingly contributing to advocacy and community engagement efforts related to gender justice, sexual and reproductive health and rights (SRHR), climate action, civic participation, economic empowerment, and community accountability. Through grassroots mobilization and rights-based programming, these organizations continue to strengthen community awareness, youth participation, and local responses to emerging social challenges.

The findings further highlight both the resilience and the structural vulnerabilities affecting youth-led organizations across the region. On one hand, many organizations demonstrate strong community legitimacy, innovation, adaptability, and commitment to addressing urgent social and development concerns affecting young people and marginalized communities. On the other hand, persistent barriers including financial insecurity, limited institutional development, inadequate technical capacity, and restricted access to policy and decision-making spaces continue to affect organizational sustainability and long-term influence.

The assessment therefore underscores the importance of strengthening youth-led ecosystems through sustained investment in institutional development, leadership strengthening, legal advocacy capacity, regional coordination, and more accessible and flexible funding mechanisms. Strengthening these areas remains essential to enhancing the effectiveness, sustainability, and policy engagement capacity of youth-led organizations across Eastern Africa.

Ultimately, the findings reflect the growing significance of youth-led organizations as important actors within regional advocacy, governance, and community transformation processes. Their continued presence within grassroots spaces highlights the critical role of youth leadership in advancing inclusive participation, rights-based development, and locally driven social change across the region.